

HOW TO USE THESE TECHNIQUES

The analytic techniques in this primer are designed to help individual analysts, as well as teams, explore and challenge their analytical arguments and mind-sets. Some techniques are fairly simple to understand and employ—such as Brainstorming and Devil’s Advocacy. Others are more complex and demand a greater degree of analytical sophistication, resource commitment, and time. All the techniques are included because they have helped other analysts avoid rigid ways of thinking or assisted them in exploring new outcomes or implications of an intelligence problem.

The techniques are grouped by their purpose: **diagnostic** techniques are primarily aimed at making analytic arguments, assumptions, or intelligence gaps more transparent; **contrarian** techniques explicitly challenge current thinking; and **imaginative thinking**

techniques aim at developing new insights, different perspectives and/or develop alternative outcomes. In fact, many of the techniques will do some combination of these functions. However, analysts will want to select the tool that best accomplishes the specific task they set out for themselves. Although application of these techniques alone is no guarantee of analytic precision or accuracy of judgments, it does improve the sophistication and credibility of intelligence assessments as well as their usefulness to policymakers. As Richards Heuer notes in his own work on cognitive bias, “analysis can be improved.”³

³ Heuer, *Psychology of Intelligence Analysis*, p. 184.